USER MANUAL

BondFlux

A simulation toolkit for dynamic bonds in polymer networks

`fix bond/flux` for LAMMPS — methods, usage and validation

LAMMPS style	`fix bond/flux`
Modes	`mc`, `3body`
Tested with	LAMMPS stable 30 Sep 2026
Source	`https://github.com/zidan0x266/BondFlux`

October 2026

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1 Introduction

BondFlux is a simulation toolkit for dynamic bonds in polymer networks: bond exchange, bond swaps, and reversible bond formation and breaking. It adds them to LAMMPS molecular dynamics of coarse-grained polymers as a single fix style, `fix bond/flux`, with two modes: hybrid MD/MC moves of topological bonds (`mc`), and the Sciortino three-body swap potential (`3body`). This manual explains the two methods, the LAMMPS commands, how to add the fix to LAMMPS, and the tests that validate it.

Dynamic covalent and supramolecular bonds let a polymer network change its topology while it is deformed or heated. BondFlux covers both classes of dynamic covalent bonds as well as reversible physical bonds:

- **Associative exchange**: vitrimers and other associative covalent adaptable networks (CANs) [1]. A bond swaps to a new partner, so the number of cross-links stays constant, as in transesterification [2], transamination of vinylogous urethanes [3], dioxaborolane metathesis [4] or imine exchange [5].
- **Dissociative exchange**: dissociative CANs such as Diels–Alder networks [6]. Bonds break and form again later, and the cross-link density depends on temperature.
- **Supramolecular and associating polymers**: reversible stickers (hydrogen bonds [7], metal–ligand complexes) that form transient networks and physical gels.
- **Double- and multiple-network elastomers**: sacrificial strands that break under load [8], combined with dynamic bonds that exchange.

Exchange, formation and breaking can be combined with each other and with the irreversible scission of bonds through `bond_style quartic`.

Two routes are used in the literature. In the first, a dynamic bond is an explicit LAMMPS bond, and an MC step between MD steps changes the topology (Perego and Khabaz [9], Xia et al. [10] [11], and others). In the second, a bond is a short-ranged pair attraction. A three-body repulsion enforces one bond per sticker and makes the bond swap barrier-free, so standard MD produces the exchange [12]. BondFlux provides both routes in the same fix (Table 1.1 →p.2).

Associative exchange uses the `mc` shift and swap moves; dissociative networks and stickers add formation and breaking, with the association energy `ebond`. In `3body` mode, $\lambda = 1$ gives barrier-free bond swaps, and $\lambda > 1$ slows them down. The MC moves satisfy detailed balance with respect to the full force field (bond style, pair style and `special_bonds` weights), in serial and in parallel. A reaction barrier (activation energy) changes the exchange rate without changing the equilibrium.

	`mc`	`3body`
dynamic bond	LAMMPS bond of one type	pair interaction within r_c
topology changes by	Metropolis MC every N steps	MD (continuous forces)
moves	shift, swap, formation, breaking	swap, thermal breaking and formation
number of bonds	conserved, or fluctuating with `form`/`break`	fluctuating (fixed if $\varepsilon \gg kT$)
rate control	attempt gate $e^{-E_a/kT}$, frequency	λ, temperature

Table 1.1 / The two modes of `fix bond/flux`.

2 Methods

2.1 Monte Carlo moves of topological bonds

The atoms of the fix group are *stickers*. Each sticker has at most one dynamic bond, a LAMMPS bond of the type `btype`. Every N steps each sticker is visited once and offered one move (Figure 2.1 → p. 3):

- a bonded sticker i with partner k breaks the bond with probability p_b (`break`), and otherwise attempts an exchange with a candidate j, chosen uniformly among the stickers within the reaction window of i: a *shift* i–$k + j \to i$–$j + k$ if j is free, or a *swap* i–$k + j$–$l \to i$–$j + k$–l if j is bonded to l;

- a free sticker i forms a bond with probability p_f (`form`), with a free candidate j chosen uniformly.

Every bond that is broken *or* formed must have a length in the reaction window $[r_{\min}, r_c)$. This rule makes each move reversible from the same sticker with the same proposal probability: in a shift, the free stickers near i before the move are the free stickers near i after it, with j and k exchanged, and both are inside the window. Candidates must be bondable (`bondable` types, `molecule` rule) and must not already be bonded to i through another bond. A bond stretched beyond r_c can therefore neither break nor exchange; under large deformation, r_c should cover the bond lengths that are to stay reactive.

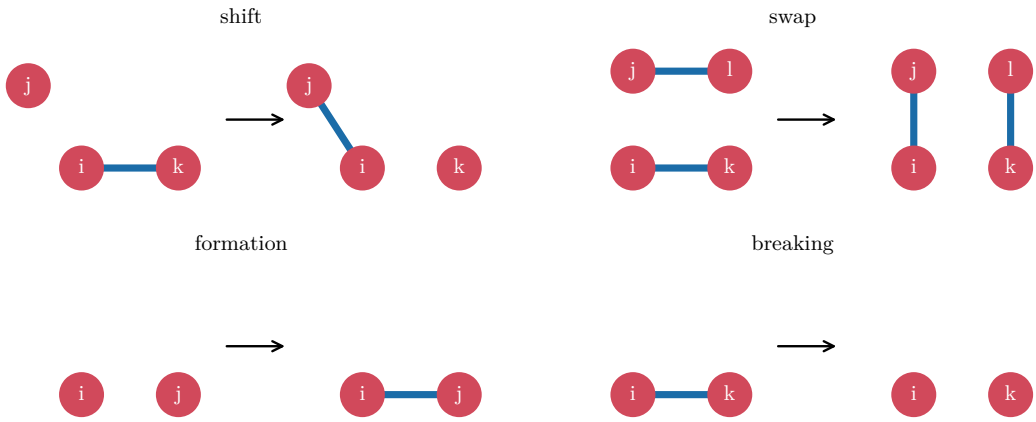


Figure 2.1 / Monte Carlo moves of `fix bond/flux mc`: sticker i is the sticker offered the move; dynamic bonds are drawn as lines. Top: exchange (shift, swap), which keeps the number of dynamic bonds. Bottom: formation and breaking, which change it.

Energy change

The energy change of a move is evaluated with the bond and pair styles of the simulation:

$$\Delta E = \sum_{\text{formed}} \Big[U_{\text{bond}}(r) - \Delta U_{\text{pair}}(r)\Big] - \sum_{\text{broken}} \Big[U_{\text{bond}}(r) - \Delta U_{\text{pair}}(r)\Big] + E_{\text{bond}}\,(n_{\text{formed}} - n_{\text{broken}}), \tag{2.2}$$

where $\Delta U_{\text{pair}}(r) = U_{\text{pair}}(r;1) - U_{\text{pair}}(r;w_{12})$ is the change of the pair energy when a pair stops being a 1–2 neighbor (w_{12} = `special_bonds` weight) and E_{bond} is an optional association energy (`ebond`). For a Kremer–Grest model [13] with `special_bonds lj 0 1 1`, a FENE bond and a WCA pair, the WCA terms cancel and ΔE is the change of the FENE energy; with `special_bonds 1 1 1` (required by `bond_style quartic`) $\Delta U_{\text{pair}} = 0$. ΔE is exactly the change of the LAMMPS potential energy, as checked in Chapter 4 → p. 12.

Acceptance

Exchange moves are accepted with $\min(1, e^{-\Delta E/kT})$. Formation and breaking are each other's reverse but are proposed with different probabilities (a free sticker picks one of n_c candidates; a bonded sticker breaks with probability p_b), so they carry the Metropolis–Hastings ratio

$$P_{\text{form}} = \min\!\left(1, \frac{p_b\, n_c}{p_f}\; e^{-\Delta E/kT}\right), \qquad P_{\text{break}} = \min\!\left(1, \frac{p_f}{p_b\, n_c'}\; e^{-\Delta E/kT}\right), \tag{2.3}$$

where n_c' is the number of free candidates of i after the bond is broken.

Barrier

A reaction barrier E_a (`barrier`) and an attempt probability P (`prob`) enter as a gate: a sticker is offered a move only with probability $g = P\, e^{-E_a/kT}$. The gate multiplies the rate of every move and of its reverse by the same factor, so it changes the kinetics and leaves the equilibrium unchanged (Section 4.2 → p. 13). Adding E_a to ΔE inside the Metropolis exponent, as in Ref. [11], does not have this property.

Parallel moves

A move centered on sticker i involves atoms within $2r_c$ of i. Each MPI sub-domain is split into 2^d sectors, and the sectors are processed one after the other; moves in the same sector of neighboring processors are then at least half a sub-domain apart and cannot conflict. Partner changes of ghost atoms are sent to their owners after each sector, also through the multi-hop paths near sub-domain corners. At the end of an MC step the bond and 1–2 special lists are updated and a reneighboring is triggered. The partner bookkeeping is rebuilt from the bond list at every MC step, so bonds broken by `bond_style quartic` are picked up automatically.

Moves within the MD step

The MC step takes place after the positions are updated and before the new forces are computed, that is between the two half-kicks of velocity Verlet. Without a correction (`impulse no`, the scheme of earlier hybrid MD/MC work) the second half-kick of that step already uses the forces of the new bonds, so the atoms of a changed bond receive the extra impulse $(\mathbf{F}_{\mathrm{new}}-\mathbf{F}_{\mathrm{old}})\,\delta t/2$, and every accepted move heats the system by about $|\Delta\mathbf{F}|^2\delta t^2/8m$. With `impulse yes` (the default) each atom whose partner changed receives the velocity change $\Delta\mathbf{v} = (\mathbf{F}_{\mathrm{old}}-\mathbf{F}_{\mathrm{new}})\,\delta t/2m$, computed from the bond and pair terms of its old and new bond only. The step then ends exactly as without the moves, the moves take place at synchronized positions and velocities, and an accepted move changes only the potential energy, by the ΔE of its Metropolis test. This is the exact splitting assumed by hybrid MD/MC; it is not a thermostat, and the jump ΔE is exchanged with the heat bath as before.

Contact diagnostics

A sticker is *in contact* while it has a candidate for its move: an exchange candidate if it is bonded (with its bond inside the window), a free candidate if it is free and bonds can form. Contacts open and close with the motion of the stickers, while moves are only offered every N steps. With `contact` N_c (a divisor of N) the fix checks the contacts every N_c steps and reports the time in contact summed over the stickers, the completed contact episodes, the episodes during which no MC step took place, their fraction f_{miss}, and k_{cond}, the accepted exchanges and formations per unit contact time. A large f_{miss} means that the MC interval filters out short contacts, so that the exchange rate depends on N in a way that the barrier does not describe; N should then be reduced.

2.2 Three-body swap potential

In `3body` mode the fix adds the Sciortino potential [12] between bondable stickers. The two-body bond is a $2n$–n Lennard-Jones potential,

$$V(r) = \varepsilon\,\frac{\phi(r)-\phi(r_c)}{1+\phi(r_c)}\,, \qquad \phi(r) = 4\Big[\Big(\frac{\sigma}{r}\Big)^{2n} - \Big(\frac{\sigma}{r}\Big)^{n}\Big], \qquad r < r_c, \tag{2.4}$$

shifted to zero at r_c and rescaled to a depth of $-\varepsilon$ at $r_{\min} = 2^{1/n}\sigma$. With `eshift no`, $V = \varepsilon\,\phi(r)$ is used unshifted, as in Ref. [12]. The three-body term,

$$E_3 = \lambda\,\varepsilon \sum_i \sum_{j<k} V_3(r_{ij})\,V_3(r_{ik}), \qquad V_3(r) = \begin{cases} 1 & r \le r_{\min} \\ -V(r)/\varepsilon & r_{\min} < r < r_c \end{cases}, \tag{2.5}$$

penalizes a sticker with two partners. With $a = V_3(r_{ij})$ and $b = V_3(r_{ik})$ for two partners beyond $r_{\min}$, the energy of the triplet is $E = \varepsilon\,(-a - b + \lambda ab)$. For $\lambda = 1$ the energy gained by a second partner is compensated exactly, so the

swap is barrier-free. For $\lambda > 1$ a sticker with two partners at the minimum costs $(\lambda - 1)\varepsilon$, and the swap passes the saddle point $a = b = 1/\lambda$, a barrier of $\varepsilon\,(1 - 1/\lambda)$, which stays below the bond energy ε. Since V_3 is built from V itself, this holds for any bond shape. Forces, energy and virial are computed in the `pre_reverse` stage on a full neighbor list, and forces on ghost atoms are summed by LAMMPS's reverse communication. The fix supplies the complete interaction between bondable sticker types; the pair style interaction between them must be switched off (`pair_coeff A B 0.0 ...`).

Stillinger–Weber shaped bond

With `3body sw` the bond has the Stillinger–Weber form

$$V(r) = \frac{\varepsilon}{N}\left[B\left(\frac{\sigma}{r}\right)^{p} - \left(\frac{\sigma}{r}\right)^{q}\right]\exp\!\left(\frac{\sigma}{r - r_c}\right), \qquad r < r_c, \quad p > q \geq 0, \tag{2.6}$$

which goes to zero with all its derivatives at r_c, so neither the energy nor the force jumps at the cutoff. The minimum $r_{\min}$ is the first zero of $\mathrm{d}V/\mathrm{d}r$ below r_c, found by bisection to machine precision, and N sets $V(r_{\min}) = -\varepsilon$.

Several sticker chemistries

The fix arguments are the parameters of every bondable pair of types; the `coeff` keyword sets them, e.g. ε_{ab}, σ_{ab}, n_{ab}, $r_{c,ab}$ and λ_{ab}, for selected pairs a–b. Each bond, and each leg of the three-body term, uses the parameters of its own pair of types. The three-body term of a triplet j–i–k is

$$E_3^{(jik)} = \min\!\left(\lambda_{ij}\varepsilon_{ij},\ \lambda_{ik}\varepsilon_{ik}\right) V_3^{(ij)}(r_{ij})\, V_3^{(ik)}(r_{ik}). \tag{2.7}$$

The minimum generalizes Sciortino's compensation: with $\lambda = 1$, a partner k approaching a stronger bond i–j leaves the energy at $-\varepsilon_{ij}$, and a stronger partner approaching a weaker bond lowers the energy monotonically to the stronger bond, so a swap between bonds of different strength has no barrier beyond their energy difference. For equal pairs the expression reduces to the single-chemistry potential. The `triplet` keyword replaces the minimum by a chosen strength for the triplets centered on one type with legs of two given types.

The three-body potential is widely used for coarse-grained vitrimers, for example by Liu, Ganesan and co-workers to relate the bond swap barrier to the structure, mechanics, self-healing and reprocessing of vitrimer networks [14], and by Sing and co-workers to study penetrant diffusion in vitrimer networks [15].

3 Using fix bond/flux in LAMMPS

3.1 Syntax

```
fix ID group-ID bond/flux mc Nevery btype rc T seed &
    keyword value ...
fix ID group-ID bond/flux 3body [lj] eps sigma n rc lambda &
    keyword value ...
fix ID group-ID bond/flux 3body sw eps sigma B p q rc lambda &
    keyword value ...
coeff values:   itype jtype (the values of the bond shape)
triplet values: itype jtype ktype strength
```

- `mc`: `Nevery` = steps between MC steps; `btype` = bond type of the dynamic bonds; `rc` = upper end of the reaction window (distance); `T` = temperature of the Metropolis test (use the thermostat set point); `seed` = random number seed.
- `3body`: `eps`, `sigma`, `n` = depth, size and exponent of the $2n$–n bond (`lj`, the default); `B`, `p`, `q` = parameters of the Stillinger–Weber shaped bond (`sw`); `rc` = cutoff; `lambda` = three-body strength.

Output

`mc`: global vector with 16 elements (attempts, proposals, accepted shifts, swaps, formations, breakings, geometric rejections, Metropolis rejections, sum of ΔE of accepted moves, number of dynamic bonds, accepted moves in the last MC step; with `contact`: contact time, contact episodes, missed episodes, k_{cond}, f_{miss}); global scalar $E_{\mathrm{bond}}\times$(number of dynamic bonds) when `ebond` is set, included in the potential energy. `3body`: global scalar = $E_2 + E_3$ (included in the potential energy and virial), vector (E_2, E_3, bonded pairs, stickers with more than one partner). Per-atom array, both modes: column 1 = partner atom ID (nearest bonded partner in `3body`), column 2 = number of moves of the atom (`mc`) or number of partners within `rbond` (`3body`).

Restrictions

`mc`: molecular atom style; orthogonal box; `special_bonds lj/coul` w_{12} `1.0 1.0` (1–3 and 1–4 neighbors must not be special); `comm_modify cutoff` $\geq 2r_c +$ skin$/2$; processor sub-domains $\geq 8r_c +$ skin; `extra/bond/per/atom` and `extra/special/per/atom` when bonds can form; angles or dihedrals must not contain dynamic bonds. For FENE bonds $r_c < 0.95R_0$; for quartic bonds r_c must be shorter than the breaking distance. LAMMPS cannot combine `quartic` with unbreakable styles

keyword	mode	value	default
`bondable`	both	`itype jtype` (ranges allowed, repeatable)	all pairs
`shift`, `swap`	mc	`yes`/`no`	`yes`
`form`, `break`	mc	attempt probabilities p_f, p_b (both > 0 or both 0)	0, 0
`ebond`	mc	association energy per dynamic bond	0
`barrier`	mc	activation energy E_a	0
`prob`	mc	attempt probability P	1
`rmin`	mc	lower end of the reaction window	0
`molecule`	mc	`any`, `inter`, `intra`	`any`
`contact`	mc	contact diagnostics every N_c steps (N_c divides N)	off
`impulse`	mc	`yes`/`no`: velocity correction at the topology switch	`yes`
`coeff`	3body	parameters of a pair of bondable types (repeatable)	fix args
`triplet`	3body	three-body strength $\lambda\varepsilon$ of a triplet (repeatable)	min rule
`rbond`	3body	distance that defines a bond for the output	`rc` of the pair
`eshift`	3body	`yes`/`no`: shift V to zero at `rc`	`yes`

Table 3.1 / Keywords of `fix bond/flux`.

in `bond_style hybrid`, so a network with breakable quartic strands uses quartic dynamic bonds as well. `3body`: `newton on`; `comm_modify cutoff` $\geq r_c +$ skin (largest r_c of all pairs). Neither mode supports `run_style respa`. The fix writes no restart data: after `read_restart` it is defined again, the partners are rebuilt from the bond list, and the per-atom move counts and random number streams start anew.

3.2 Examples

Kremer–Grest vitrimer

Exchange only, number of bonds conserved (`examples/kg_network`):

```
special_bonds   lj/coul 0.0 1.0 1.0
bond_style      fene
bond_coeff      * 30.0 1.5 1.0 1.0
group           stick type 2
fix             flux stick bond/flux mc 100 2 1.3 1.0 777 barrier 2.0
    &
                contact 10
```

The contact diagnostics show that MC steps every 100 steps miss about 40 % of the contacts; `-var nevery 10` resolves them (Chapter 4 → p. 12).

Dissociative network

Reversible formation and breaking with association energy:

```
fix             flux stick bond/flux mc 100 2 1.3 1.0 12347 &
                form 1.0 break 0.5 ebond -24.0
```

Multiple network with breakable strands

Quartic bonds; type 1 = permanent strands, type 2 = dynamic junctions; strands break irreversibly above 1.3σ:

```
special_bonds   lj/coul 1.0 1.0 1.0
bond_style      quartic
bond_coeff      1 1200.0 -0.55 0.25 1.3 34.6878
bond_coeff      2 1200.0 -0.55 0.25 1.3 34.6878
fix             flux stick bond/flux mc 10 2 1.2 1.0 4321 barrier 3.0
```

Cross-linker vitrimer

As in Refs. [10] [11]: A stickers on chains, B ends of three-bead cross-linkers, LJ with $r_c = 1.5\sigma$, MC every 10 steps, reaction window $0.87 \leq r < 1.14$; only free A stickers attack bonded B:

```
special_bonds   lj/coul 0.0 1.0 1.0
bond_coeff      2 30.0 1.5 0.0 1.0      # FENE without the WCA term
fix             flux AB bond/flux mc 10 2 1.14 1.0 9876 &
                bondable 1 2 swap no rmin 0.87 barrier ${Ub}
```

Pair-swap vitrimer

As in Ref. [9]: all stickers bonded, swaps only, an MC step every MD step:

```
fix             flux stick bond/flux mc 1 2 1.3 1.0 5555 shift no
```

Sciortino dumbbells

`examples/dumbbells`; A–A and B–B repulsive $2n$–n WCA:

```
pair_style      mie/cut $(2.0^(1.0/100))
pair_coeff      * * 1.0 1.0 200 100
pair_coeff      1 2 0.0 1.0 200 100
pair_modify     shift yes
fix             tb stick bond/flux 3body 1.0 1.0 100 1.3 1.0 &
                bondable 1 2
```

The model of Ref. [15] corresponds to `3body 30.0 1.0 100 1.2 lambda`. With `-var shape sw` the example uses the Stillinger–Weber shaped bond instead, `3body sw 1.0 1.0 0.5 100 50 1.3 lambda`, which is close to the $2n$–n bond with $n = 100$ but goes to zero smoothly at the cutoff.

Two sticker chemistries

`examples/dumbbells/in.two_chemistries`: A particles (type 1) bond to B (type 2) with $\varepsilon = 1$ and to C (type 3) with ε_C (default 0.95); the triplet strength of A with a B and a C leg is $\min(1, \varepsilon_C)$ unless set with `-var trip`:

```
fix             tb stick bond/flux 3body 1.0 1.0 100 1.3 1.0 &
                bondable 1 2 bondable 1 3 &
                coeff 1 3 ${epsC} 1.0 100 1.3 1.0 triplet 1 2 3
   ${trip}
compute         nAB B reduce sum f_tb[2]      # A-B bonds
compute         nAC C reduce sum f_tb[2]      # A-C bonds
```

3.3 Adding BondFlux to LAMMPS

The fix uses only core LAMMPS classes and is compiled as part of the LAMMPS core. With CMake:

```
cd lammps/src
# link (or copy) the two files
ln -s ../../src/fix_bond_flux.h ../../src/fix_bond_flux.cpp .
cd ..
cmake -S cmake -B build -D PKG_MOLECULE=on -D PKG_EXTRA-PAIR=on \
      -D BUILD_MPI=on -D BUILD_SHARED_LIBS=on
cmake --build build -j 8
build/lmp -h | grep bond/flux
```

`PKG_MOLECULE` provides the bond styles, `PKG_EXTRA-PAIR` the `mie/cut` pair style of the dumbbell examples, and `BUILD_SHARED_LIBS` the library for the Python tests. With the legacy make build, copy the two files into `lammps/src` and run `make mpi`. BondFlux was developed and tested with LAMMPS stable 30 Sep 2026.

4 Validity tests

The scripts are in `tests/` and `examples/`; the figure data are in `doc/data/bondflux_validation.h5`. Times are in Lennard-Jones units $\tau = \sigma\sqrt{m/\varepsilon}$. The bond autocorrelation $C(t)$ is the fraction of bonds present at time 0 that are present at time t; τ_x is its decay time.

4.1 Exact detailed balance of the MC moves

Six stickers are frozen in place (no time integration), so only the MC moves change the system. The visited topologies must then follow $e^{-E/kT}$ over all topologies the moves can reach. The reachable topologies and their energies are enumerated independently of LAMMPS (`tests/test_mc_balance.py`). The test was run for four force fields: Kremer–Grest FENE with `special_bonds 0 1 1`; quartic with `1 1 1`; FENE without WCA, where bonded pairs lose their repulsion; and harmonic with a 1–2 weight of 0.5. It covered exchange only, formation and breaking only, and both together, with and without a barrier, on 1, 2 and 4 MPI ranks, with the cluster in the middle of the box and across a periodic box corner. All 48 runs pass: the largest block z-score is below 3.1, the total variation distance below 0.006, and the LAMMPS potential energy changes by the sum of the ΔE of the accepted moves to 10^{-10}. Figure 4.1 →p.12 shows the run with formation and breaking on 4 ranks.

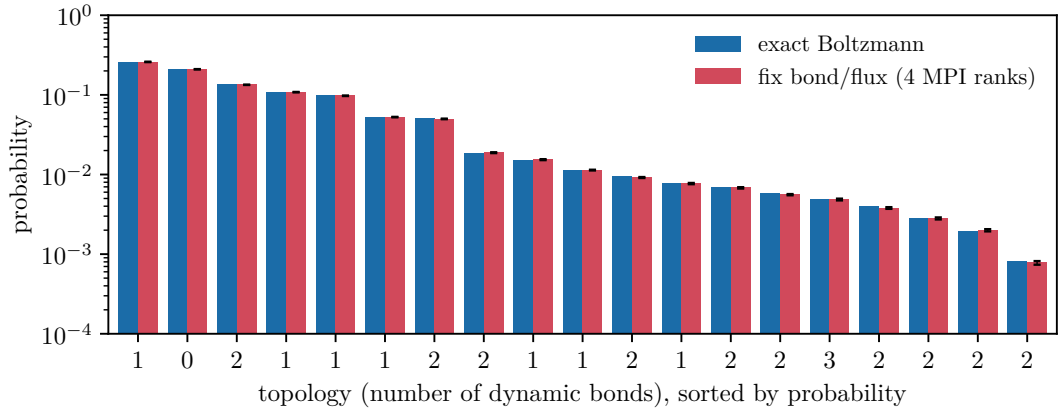


Figure 4.1 / Probabilities of the 19 reachable topologies of a frozen six-sticker cluster (0, 1 or 2 dynamic bonds) with exchange, formation and breaking ($p_f = p_b = 0.5$, $E_{\mathrm{bond}} = -20\varepsilon$, $kT = 4\varepsilon$, Kremer–Grest FENE, 4×10^5 MC steps on 4 MPI ranks) compared with the exact Boltzmann distribution. Total variation distance 0.0018.

4.2 Barrier as a gate versus inside the Metropolis exponent

For the same cluster, the transition matrix of the exchange MC was built exactly and its stationary distribution compared with the Boltzmann distribution (`tests/compare_acceptance_rules.py`). With the gate of `fix bond/flux` the stationary distribution is Boltzmann for every barrier. With the barrier added to ΔE, a move and its reverse are both penalized, so for $|\Delta E| < E_a$ their acceptance ratio becomes $e^{-2\Delta E/kT}$. The equilibrium of the topology is then that of half the temperature (Table 4.2 → p. 13).

rule	window	$E_a/kT = 0$	1	2	4	8
gate	$[0, 1.3)$	2×10^{-15}	2×10^{-14}	1×10^{-14}	1×10^{-13}	2×10^{-11}
exponent	$[0, 1.3)$	2×10^{-15}	0.235	0.275	0.283	0.283
gate	$[0.87, 1.14)$	3×10^{-17}	6×10^{-16}	2×10^{-15}	1×10^{-14}	4×10^{-13}
exponent	$[0.87, 1.14)$	3×10^{-17}	0.149	0.149	0.149	0.149

Table 4.2 / Total variation distance between the stationary distribution and the Boltzmann distribution (exact, no sampling). Gate (`fix bond/flux`): $P_{\text{acc}} = e^{-E_a/kT} \min(1, e^{-\Delta E/kT})$; exponent: $P_{\text{acc}} = \min(1, e^{-(\Delta E + E_a)/kT})$.

A reaction window checked only for the new bond [10] is not reversible either: a bond stretched beyond the window can be exchanged away but never formed. This bias acts through bond-length fluctuations and does not appear for a frozen cluster.

4.3 Kremer–Grest sticker network

A melt of 200 Kremer–Grest chains of 20 beads with stickers at beads 2, 6, 10, 14 and 18 (`examples/kg_network`) is first turned into a dissociative network: stickers form and break bonds with $E_{\text{bond}} = -24\varepsilon$ at $kT = 1$, and the number of bonds settles at about 400 of 500 possible (Figure 4.3 (a)). With formation and breaking switched off, the number of bonds is conserved (409 bonds before and after 2×10^5 steps for every barrier) and the shift and swap moves relax the topology. The barrier enters as the gate $e^{-E_a/kT}$: going from $E_a = 0$ to 2ε and 4ε reduces the number of attempts by factors of 7.40 and 7.33 per step of $2kT$ and the number of accepted exchanges by 7.45 and 7.2, close to $e^2 = 7.39$. The bond autocorrelation time grows from $\tau_x = 128\tau$ to 739τ and about 4300τ (the last value extrapolated beyond the run), a factor of 5–6 per $2kT$, because exchanges that swap a bond back restore the original pairing (Figure 4.3 (b)).

With `contact 10` and $E_a = 0$, MC steps every 100 steps (as in the example) miss 42 % of the contact episodes resolved every 10 steps, and k_{cond} is $0.012\,\tau^{-1}$; with MC steps every 10 steps no episode is missed and $k_{\text{cond}} = 0.115\,\tau^{-1}$. The barrier

scaling above is not affected, but rates in this example are set partly by the MC interval.

4.4 Energy with MC moves in NVE

An accepted move changes the potential energy by its ΔE, so in NVE the quantity $E_{\text{total}} - \sum \Delta E$ (`f_ID[9]` sums the ΔE) should stay constant. In the Kremer–Grest network of `examples/kg_network` without a thermostat (2×10^4 steps, MC every 100 steps, about 1000 accepted exchanges) the total energy without moves is conserved to $\pm 5\varepsilon$. With moves and `impulse no`, $E_{\text{total}} - \sum \Delta E$ rises by 0.16ε per accepted move at $\delta t = 0.01$ and by 0.046ε at $\delta t = 0.005$ (nearly the factor 4 of the δt^2 heating). With `impulse yes` the rise is 0.0095ε per move at $\delta t = 0.01$, the ordinary integration error of freshly formed stiff bonds, and -0.0003ε at $\delta t = 0.005$. `tests/test_nve.py` repeats the check in a gas of dimers with about 9×10^4 accepted moves on 1 and 4 ranks: without the correction the quantity rises by 840–890ε, with it by 13–62ε without a trend. This remainder is a random walk: with a finite time step the energy that velocity Verlet conserves differs from E_{total} by an $O(\delta t^2)$ term of the forces, which changes at every move.

4.5 Contact diagnostics

`tests/test_contact.py` runs a gas of A–B dimers and free A stickers in which the moves are blocked by a barrier of $60\,kT$, so that the topology stays fixed and the contacts can be recounted exactly from the trajectory written at every check. The contact time, the number of episodes and the number of missed episodes equal the recount on 1, 2 and 4 ranks, for MC steps at every check (no missed episodes) and at every tenth check. A second system of rings A–B–A′–B′, with dynamic bonds A–B and A′–B′ and permanent bonds B–A′ and B′–A, checks with swaps on and the atoms sorted at every step that a permanent neighbor inside the reaction window is never counted as a candidate.

4.6 Three-body forces and virial

`tests/test_3body.py` compares the forces with central finite differences of the total energy, and the virial with finite-difference strain derivatives (box scaling in x, y, z and an xy shear). The test uses $n = 12$ and 100, $\lambda = 1$ and 1.3, and 1, 2 and 4 MPI ranks. The relative errors are $\leq 8 \times 10^{-10}$ for the forces and $\leq 3 \times 10^{-9}$ for the virial, and the parallel forces agree with the serial ones to 2×10^{-13}. For an A–B bond at $r_{\min}$ and a second B approaching from the other side, the total energy stays $-\varepsilon$ to 10^{-12} while the two-body energy varies between -2ε and $-\varepsilon$ ($n = 100$, $\lambda = 1$).

With `--coeff`, C stickers bond to A with their own parameters ($\varepsilon = 1.6$, $\sigma = 0.95$, $n = 18$, $r_c = 1.25$, $\lambda = 1.2$), so the cluster contains triplets with one B and one C

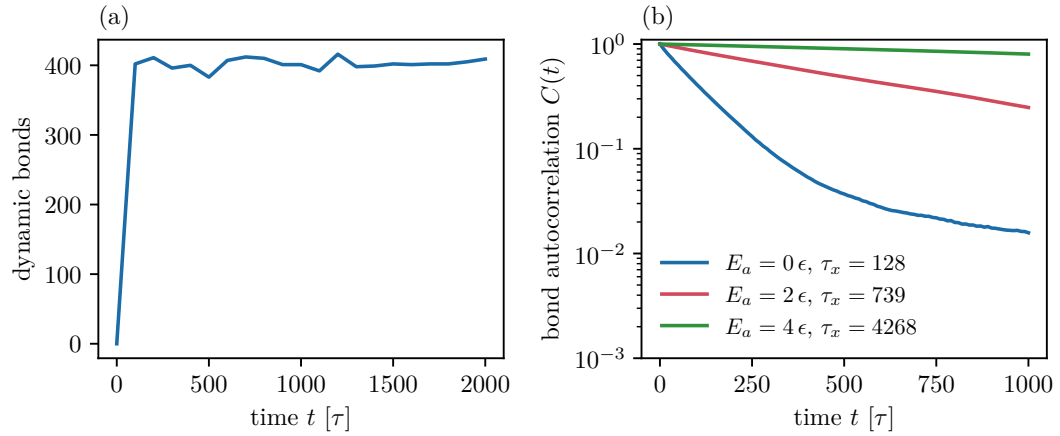


Figure 4.3 / Kremer–Grest sticker network. (a) Number of dynamic bonds during reversible formation and breaking. (b) Bond autocorrelation $C(t)$ in the same network with exchange only, for three barriers.

leg. Forces and virial agree with finite differences to the same accuracy on 1, 2 and 4 ranks, and a `coeff` equal to the default parameters reproduces the energy and forces exactly. For the mixing rule, A–B ($\varepsilon = 1$) and A–C ($\varepsilon = 0.6$) bonds with $n = 100$ and $\lambda = 1$ are used: a C approaching an A–B bond leaves the energy at -1 to 10^{-12}, and a B approaching an A–C bond lowers it monotonically, following $E = -0.6 - 0.4\,V_3^{(AB)}$ to 10^{-16}. A `triplet` strength of 1.0 for A with B and C legs replaces the minimum: the energy then follows $E = -1 + 0.4\,V_3^{(AC)}$ to 10^{-16}, a barrier of 0.4ε.

With `--form sw` the same checks are made for the Stillinger–Weber shaped bond ($B = 0.5$, $p = 12$, $q = 6$, $r_c = 1.5$; and $\varepsilon = 1.6$, $\sigma = 0.95$, $B = 0.6$, $p = 10$, $q = 4$, $r_c = 1.4$, $\lambda = 1.2$ for A–C), with a triplet strength of 0.8 for A with B and C legs: forces and virial agree with finite differences to the same accuracy on 1, 2 and 4 ranks. At the minimum found independently in the test, the bond energy is $-\varepsilon$ to 10^{-12}, and the landscape for $\lambda = 1$ is flat to 10^{-12}.

4.7 Dumbbells: comparison to the reference and bond-swap tuning

The dumbbell system of Ref. [12] has 400 A and 600 B particles at $\rho = 0.125$, with $n = 100$, $r_c = 1.3$ and $kT = 0.03$ (`examples/dumbbells/in.dumbbells`: 1000τ equilibration, 2000τ production, Langevin damping time 100). All 400 A particles are bonded at all times, and for $\lambda = 1$ the bond autocorrelation decays exponentially with $\tau_x = 116.7\tau$, against 116τ in Ref. [12] (Figure 4.4 (a)). For $\lambda = 1.1$ the lifetime grows 3.5 times to $\tau_x = 404\tau$, and for $\lambda = 1.3$ the bonds practically do not exchange within 1000τ.

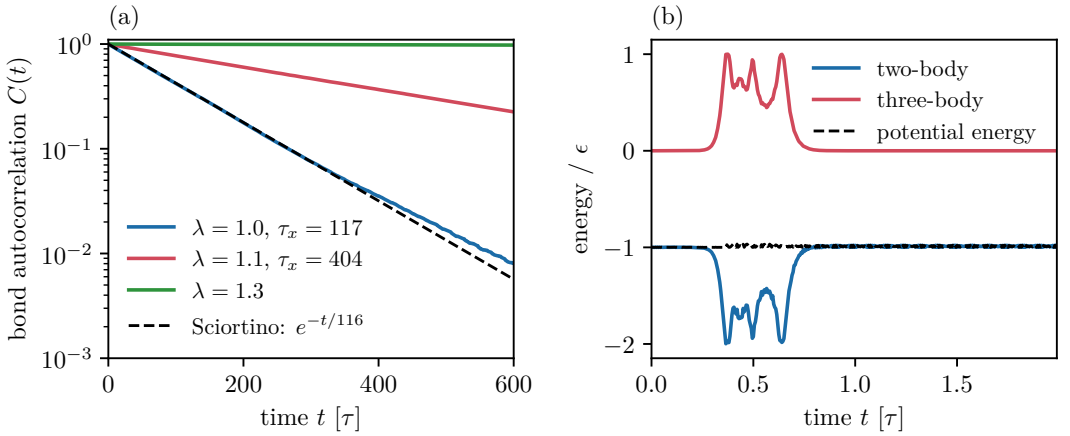


Figure 4.4 / Three-body swap potential. (a) Bond autocorrelation $C(t)$ of the dumbbell system for $\lambda = 1$, 1.1 and 1.3, with the reference decay $e^{-t/116}$ of Ref. [12]. (b) Energies during a burst of bond swaps of one A and two B particles ($n = 150$, $\lambda = 1$, NVE, $kT \approx 0.01$); the two-body and three-body energies compensate and the total potential energy stays at $-\varepsilon$.

4.8 Potential energy during a swap event

One A and two B particles move in NVE in a box of side 2.6 ($n = 150$, $\lambda = 1$, `examples/dumbbells/in.swap_event`). During a swap, the two-body energy drops to -2ε while the three-body energy rises to $+\varepsilon$, so the potential energy stays at $-\varepsilon$ (Figure 4.4 (b)). The total energy is conserved to 10^{-5} over 1.5×10^5 steps.

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